# THE LAST TRAIN HOME

The rain had been falling for almost an hour when Daniel stepped out of the café. The streets were unusually quiet, and the yellow lights reflected on the wet pavement like tiny pieces of gold.

He checked his phone.

"Where are you?"

It was a message from his old friend, Alex.

Daniel smiled. They had been friends since university, nearly fifteen years. But lately, their friendship had started to fall apart. They rarely met, their conversations had become superficial, and neither of them seemed willing to talk about it.

Daniel put his phone away and started walking toward the train station.

"Daniel!"

He stopped.

Alex was standing across the street, completely soaked. His hair was dripping, and he was breathing heavily.

"You actually came," Alex said.

"You said it was important."

"It is."

They stood there for a moment, listening to the rain.

"I heard you're leaving tomorrow," Alex finally said.

Daniel nodded. "I'm moving to Canada."

"I know."

"You knew?"

"Your sister told me."

Daniel looked away. "I was going to tell you."

"But you didn't."

There was an uncomfortable silence.

Alex took a deep breath. “Do you know what hurts the most? It isn't that you're leaving. It's that I found out from someone else.”

Daniel felt a lump in his throat.

“I didn't know how to tell you,” he admitted. “Everything has changed between us. I thought maybe... you wouldn't care.”

Alex looked at him in disbelief.

“Of course I care. You're my best friend.”

Daniel laughed quietly. “Are we? We haven't spoken properly in months.”

“That doesn't mean the friendship disappeared.”

Daniel looked at his friend. For the first time in months, neither of them was trying to hide behind small talk.

“I'll be honest,” Daniel said. “I've been avoiding you because I felt like you were judging every decision I made.”

Alex lowered his eyes.

“And I'll be honest too,” he said. “I was jealous.”

“Jealous?”

“You got the job you wanted. You're moving abroad. Your life seems to be moving forward, while mine feels stuck.”
Daniel didn't know what to say.

Then he smiled.

“You could have told me.”

“I know.”

“And I could have told you how I felt.”

“I know.”

The station announcement suddenly echoed through the street.
“The final train will arrive in five minutes.”

Alex looked at Daniel.

“So… is this goodbye?”

Daniel shook his head.

“No. It's just a different chapter.”
The train arrived with a loud screech. Daniel picked up his suitcase.
Before stepping inside, he turned around.
“Alex?”
“Yeah?”
“Promise me something.”
“What?”
“Don't let distance decide whether we're friends.”
Alex smiled.
“Deal.”
The doors began to close.
Daniel watched his friend through the glass as the train slowly disappeared into the darkness.

**For the first time in years, he understood something simple: a genuinely good friend isn't someone who is always there physically. It's someone who is willing to be honest, listen, forgive, and stand by you, even when life pulls you in different directions.**

**Sometimes friendships don't end.**

**Sometimes, they simply grow up.**